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CODEX OF THE WILL

Adherence, habit and coming back: why good plans collapse, and how to build one that survives the bad days

VILLUMINATIONS

Fine edition, 2026

Original work · First edition, 2026

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ABOUT THIS WORK

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How to read this book. It is a book about *adherence*: about why a perfectly good plan gets abandoned, and what can be built so that it survives the bad days. It is not a treatise on clinical psychology. Nothing that follows diagnoses or treats an eating disorder, a depression or an addiction, and it does not replace care from a registered health professional. If you recognise yourself in any of that, that is the first step — not this book.

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CHAPTER 1

THE BOOK THAT DOES NOT TALK ABOUT MOTIVATION

How much to eat and how much to move are settled questions: the numbers exist, and they are public. This book is about the problem that makes those numbers worthless, which is that almost nobody sticks to them for more than a few weeks. And it deals with that without appealing even once to willpower, because willpower is precisely what is not available at eleven o'clock on a Tuesday night.

WHAT THIS BOOK CLAIMS

Adherence is not a character trait: it is the outcome of a design. The person who keeps going rarely has more willpower than the person who quits; they have fewer decisions to make, less friction along the way, and a plan that survives the bad days because it was built expecting them.

That turns the problem into something you can work on. Motivation cannot be manufactured on demand; the environment, the size of the commitment, the time of day and the response to a lapse all can.

WHAT THIS BOOK DOES NOT CLAIM

- It is not clinical psychology and it does not treat disorders. If an eating disorder, a depression, an anxiety disorder or an addiction is involved,

this book is not the tool and may even get in the way. The tool is a mental health professional.

- It does not promise that you will want to train. No technique in here manufactures desire, and most of them are designed precisely to work when there is none.
- It does not turn discipline into a moral virtue. Failing a plan says nothing about who you are, and a good part of this book consists of dismantling that reading, which has driven more people out of the gym than anything else.
- It measures nothing about the body. There are no kilos here, no percentages, no before-and-after photographs.

WHERE THIS BOOK PARTS COMPANY WITH ITS SOURCES

A book on nutrition or on training rests almost entirely on official figures. Here that is only partly possible: the U.S. Army's mental-readiness doctrine is public and provides a solid frame, and the physical activity guidelines have a section on behaviour-change strategies. But several of the most useful ideas in this field come from academic literature that is NOT in the public domain. When I use one of them, I will say so in the same sentence and will not dress it up as a government recommendation. That is the difference between citing and pretending.



HOW WHAT FOLLOWS IS PUT TOGETHER

The next chapter sets out the framework of the five domains of readiness, which is the frame of the whole book and the best diagnostic tool I know for working out WHERE to start. Then come the variable that rules the outcome, the mechanics of a repeated behaviour, the plan that survives the bad day, and the distinction between a lapse and quitting — the chapter most people would have needed to read before they stopped.

The last four deal with what surrounds all of that: the environment, comparison, coming back after months off, and the limits of what a book like this can fix. That final chapter is, by some distance, the most important one in the book.

CHAPTER 2

THE FIVE DOMAINS

The public doctrine this book draws on does not organise a person's condition into “body and mind”. It organises it into five domains that hold each other up, and the underlying idea is the only one that explains why so many people do everything right in one of them and still get nowhere.



WHAT BREAKS FIRST WHEN THAT DOMAIN IS LOW

PHYSICAL	Independence goes and injuries appear
NUTRITIONAL	You do not recover from what you train
MENTAL	Nothing holds for more than a few weeks
SLEEP	The other four sink at once
SPIRITUAL	Only you can judge it, so it is not judged here

DIAGNOSTIC WHEEL · THE LOWEST ONE RULES

THE FIVE DOMAINS AND WHAT BREAKS IN EACH ONE The wheel is not an index: it is a diagnostic tool. The bottom row says what fails first when that domain is low, and the lowest domain is always where to start. The fifth is named and not developed: it is no business of a fitness book to tell anyone what gives their life meaning.

THE FIVE, AND WHAT BREAKS WHEN EACH ONE IS LOW

PHYSICAL	Strength, endurance, mobility and power. If it is low: independence goes and injuries appear
NUTRITIONAL	What goes in and when. If it is low: you do not recover from what you train
MENTAL	Goals, attention, self-talk and arousal. If it is low: nothing holds for more than a few weeks
SLEEP	Duration, timing and quality. If it is low: the other four sink at once
SPIRITUAL	Meaning, values and your own purpose. If it is low: only you can judge it, and that is why it is not judged here

THE RULE THAT MAKES THE MODEL USEFUL

A domain in poor shape limits the others, and it does so silently. Someone sleeping five hours will not perform in the gym however excellent the programme. Someone eating badly does not recover. Someone whose head is elsewhere sustains no habit, however good the design. The failing link is not compensated by squeezing the others: it drags them down.

From that comes the most useful diagnostic advice in this book: when something is not working, the right question is not “how do I try harder?” but “which of the five is broken?”. Nine times out of ten it is sleep, and almost nobody looks there first.



THE FIFTH DOMAIN, AND WHY I DO NOT DEAL WITH IT

The original doctrine includes a domain of meaning, values and purpose. I mention it because leaving it out without saying so would misreport the source, and I do not develop it because it is not my place. A book that sells you training has no authority whatsoever to tell you what you live for, and the fitness industry has spent years crossing that line with results ranging from the ridiculous to the harmful.

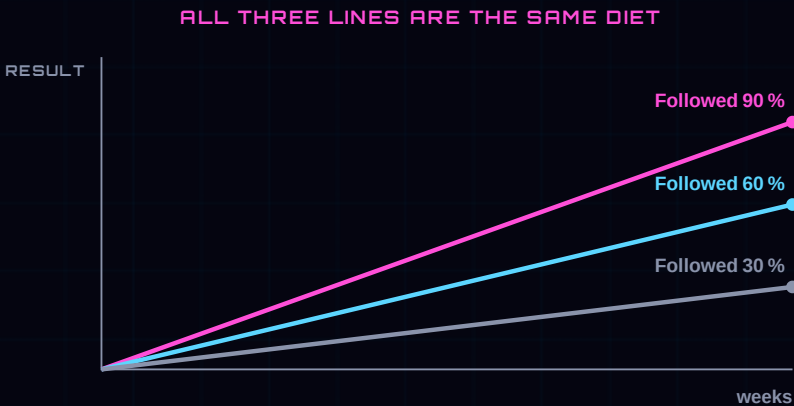
The only thing I will say is that the connection exists and is in the doctrine: people sustain better the habits that fit something they genuinely care about, and worse the ones that only fit an image they want to project. What you genuinely care about is yours, not this book's.

HOW TO USE THIS IN PRACTICE

Score yourself from one to five on the first four domains, today, without overthinking it. The lowest is where your next month of work lies, and it is almost never the one you were about to pick.

THE ONE VARIABLE THAT RULES

There is an argument that takes up half the internet and that is badly put from its very first line: which is the best diet, which is the best training method. The answer, as soon as you look at what happens over months rather than weeks, is always the same one — and it is inconvenient for everybody who is selling something.



THE VARIABLE IS NOT THE METHOD · IT IS HOW MUCH YOU DO

CONCEPTUAL DIAGRAM · NOT DATA FROM A STUDY

THE SAME DIET, THREE DEGREES OF ADHERENCE The three lines represent the same method applied with different levels of adherence. The gap between them is wider than the gap you usually find between two different reasonable methods. This is a conceptual diagram and not data from a specific study: it says which variable rules, not exactly by how much.

WHAT THIS PLATE MEANS

Two different plans, both reasonable, followed equally well, tend to give similar results. The same plan followed ninety per cent of the time and thirty per cent of the time gives results that look nothing alike. So the question “which is better?” is less useful than the question “which will I actually follow?”, and only you can answer the second one, because it depends on your schedule, your kitchen, your job and what you like to eat.

From this comes a rule for choosing that runs against all the marketing in the sector: between two plans, pick the worse of the two if it is the one you will keep up. A mediocre plan run for two years beats an optimal one run for five weeks hands down, and that is most people's real situation, not a hypothesis.



THE THREE REASONS A GOOD PLAN COLLAPSES

TOO BIG

The initial commitment is sized against day-one enthusiasm, which is a temporary state. When the enthusiasm drops back to normal, the plan is still day-one sized and no longer fits.

TOO MUCH FRICTION

Every step that comes before the behaviour is a chance for it not to happen. A gym forty minutes away, a meal that requires buying four unusual things, an app you have to open and update. Friction is not noticeable on day one and it decides month three.

ALL OR NOTHING

The plan makes no allowance for a lapse, so the first lapse invalidates the whole thing. It is the most common cause and the easiest to fix, and it has a chapter of its own.

WHAT THE OFFICIAL GUIDELINES DO SAY ABOUT THIS

The physical activity guidelines give space to behaviour-change strategies and mention, among others, goal setting, self-monitoring, social support and modifying the environment. This is not a discovery of this book: it is a little-read section of a much-cited document.

THE LOOP AND ITS THREE LEVERS

A repeated behaviour has a very simple structure: something sets it off, something gets done, and something keeps the whole thing going. All three pieces can be worked on, but they do not cost the same, and almost everyone tries to work on precisely the hardest one.



YOU ACT ON THE CUE AND ON THE REWARD · THE ROUTINE IS THE HARDEST

THE LOOP, WITH THE THREE POINTS WHERE YOU CAN INTERVENE The cue, the routine and the reward. The routine is the visible part and the hardest to change by direct decision; the cue and the reward can be manipulated with far less effort, and they are what actually moves the loop.

THE CUE: CHANGE THE ENVIRONMENT INSTEAD OF THE PERSON

A behaviour that depends on remembering is a fragile behaviour. One that is tied to something that already happens every day is not. That is why the highest-yield intervention is not resolving to train more: it is deciding which existing cue the training hooks onto.

- On leaving work, before getting home. Walking through your own front door is an extremely powerful cue that the day is over, and very few people go back out again.
- Right after dropping off the children, after the first meeting, after closing the laptop. The day already has hinges in it: use those.
- Clothes laid out the night before, in plain sight. It sounds trivial and it removes an entire decision from the morning.

THE REWARD: MAKE IT IMMEDIATE

The structural problem with exercise and with eating well is that the reward arrives months later and the cost arrives now. No behaviour holds up naturally on those terms, which is why you have to manufacture an immediate consequence that does exist.

- Ticking the box on a calendar you can see. Ridiculously simple, and one of the best-documented things there is: visible self-monitoring is one of the strategies the guidelines themselves mention.
- Tying the training to something enjoyable that happens only there: a series, an album, a podcast you listen to at no other time.

- Paying attention to how you feel thirty minutes AFTER the session, not during it. The lift in mood and energy that follows a session is immediate and is described in the guidelines among the acute benefits. It is a real reward, and you have to learn to notice it.

THE ROUTINE: THE PART YOU BARELY TOUCH

Removing a behaviour leaves a hole, and the hole fills back up with the same thing. Replacing it works far better: the cue and the reward stay the same and what changes is the bit in the middle. Someone who snacks in the afternoon out of boredom does not stop by forbidding it; they stop when there is something else to do at that moment that serves the same function.

WHERE THIS IDEA COMES FROM, AND WHERE IT DOES NOT

The cue–routine–reward scheme is classic material from the psychology of learning and does not come from this book's government sources. I use it because it is the cleanest frame I know, and I say so to make clear which part of the book is backed by an official body and which part is a conceptual framework in common use.

CHAPTER 5

THE PLAN THAT SURVIVES THE BAD DAY

Every plan has two versions: the one you do when everything is going well and the one you do when it is not. Almost nobody writes the second, and the second is the one that decides the outcome, because bad days are not the exception: they are roughly a third of all days.

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE MINIMUM

The most useful technique in this book fits in one sentence: define a tiny version of your plan that gets done always, whatever happens, and treat it as non-negotiable. It is not the target; it is the floor.

EXAMPLES OF A FLOOR

TRAINING	Ten minutes. Put your kit on and do ten minutes. If you want to stop after that, you stop and it counts all the same.
FOOD	That the main meal has vegetables and protein in it. The rest of the day can be whatever it can be.
SLEEP	Going to bed at the same time even if you sleep badly. The time is what is non-negotiable, not the number of hours.
LOGGING	One line in the notebook. Even if the line says you did nothing today.

The floor does two things at once. It keeps the behaviour alive — which is what is really being protected, more than the physiological effect of those ten minutes— and it removes the mental category of “a lost day”, which is what drags the following days down with it.

And it has a side effect you do not go looking for but that happens anyway: quite a few of those days when you were only going to do ten minutes end in the full session, because the resistance was in starting and not in the effort. The ones that do not, count too.



THE IF-THEN PLAN

The second technique consists of deciding in advance what you will do in the specific situation that usually derails the plan, in the form of a sentence with two halves: if X happens, then I do Y.

- If I leave work late, then I do the short session at home instead of going to the gym.
- If dinner has something on the table that does not fit, then I serve myself once and do not go back for more, and I change nothing else about the day.
- If I wake up without any desire to do it, then I put my kit on and go out for ten minutes before deciding anything.
- If I miss two days in a row, then the third one is the floor and not the full session.

What this technique does is move the decision out of a bad moment—rushed, tired and hungry—and into a good one, which is when you write the sentence. Deciding is expensive, and at the critical moment there is no budget for it. I will write it again: this idea comes from psychology literature that is not in the public domain; the mechanism it describes is common sense, and that is why it is here.

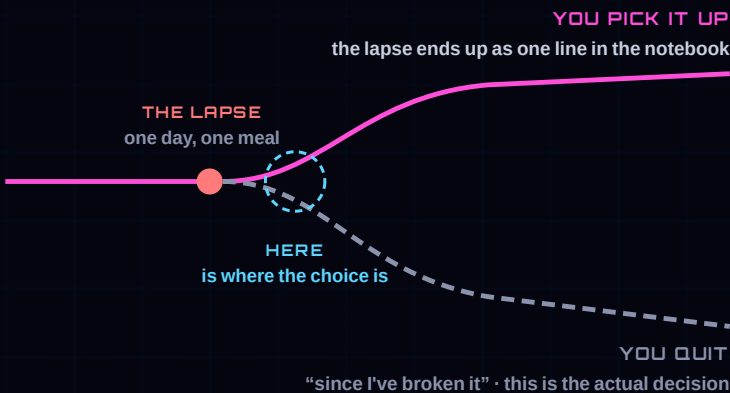
HOW TO WRITE AN IF-THEN THAT WORKS

Concrete in both halves. “If I am short of time, then I will organise myself better” is not a plan: it names neither a situation nor a behaviour. “If I have not left the office by seven, then I do the twenty-minute session in the living room” is one. A useful if-then can be executed without thinking, and that is all that is asked of it.

CHAPTER 6

A LAPSE AND A RELAPSE ARE NOT THE SAME THING

This is the most important chapter in the book, and the one most people would have needed to read before they quit. A lapse and quitting are two different things separated by a decision, and that decision is taken after the lapse, not during it.



THE LAPSE IS NOT THE RELAPSE · THE RELAPSE COMES AFTER

THE FORK THAT COMES AFTER THE LAPSE The lapse is a point, not a direction. What decides the outcome is what happens in the hours that follow: picking it up again leaves the lapse as one line in the notebook; the "since I've broken it anyway" reasoning turns one day into a season. The choice is marked after the point, not at it.

THE REASONING THAT DOES THE DAMAGE

It has a recognisable shape: “since I’ve already broken the diet, today no longer matters”. “I’ve lost the week now, I’ll start on Monday”. “I’m not one of the people who train any more”. All three sentences turn an isolated data point into an identity, and an identity does last.

It is an error of logic before it is a problem of willpower. Missing one meal out of twenty-one does not change the week appreciably; what changes it is abandoning the other twenty. The damage is not in the lapse: it is entirely in the reaction to the lapse, and the arithmetic is clear enough that it is worth doing out loud next time.



THE TWENTY-FOUR-HOUR PROTOCOL

- 1** Log the lapse in the notebook. No adjectives: what happened and in what situation. Logging it turns it into data rather than a verdict.
- 2** Do not compensate. Do not train twice as hard, do not skip the next meal, do not fast as a punishment. Compensating reinforces the idea that a moral debt was incurred, and that idea is the problem.
- 3** Go back to the plan at the next meal or on the next day, without waiting for Monday. The word “Monday” is the warning sign of this chapter.
- 4** After a week, look at the log and find the pattern. Lapses repeat in the same situations —Friday, the trip, dinner out, the day you sleep badly— and a repeating situation is not fixed with more willpower: it is fixed with an if-then written for it.

THE SENTENCE THAT SUMS UP THE CHAPTER

A lapse is information about the plan; quitting is a decision about yourself. Only the second has consequences, and only the second can be avoided at will.

CHAPTER 7

PERFORMANCE SKILLS, ACCORDING TO A PUBLIC MANUAL

This is where the book can cite an official and fairly little-known source. The U.S. Army's health and physical readiness manual devotes a whole domain to mental readiness and describes a set of trainable skills. It is published in full and downloads free of charge, and its content is far less epic and far more useful than its provenance suggests.

THE SKILLS THE DOCTRINE DESCRIBES

GOAL SETTING	Concrete, measurable, staged goals, with a process goal —what you will do— alongside the outcome goal.
IMAGERY, OR MENTAL REHEARSAL	Running through the execution mentally before doing it, in the first person and with sensory detail.
SELF-TALK	What you say to yourself during the effort. It is trainable, and it is changed by replacing, not by suppressing.
AROUSAL CONTROL	Raising or lowering the level of arousal at will. Slow breathing is the tool for bringing it down; tempo, volume and posture are the tools for taking it up.
ATTENTION CONTROL	Choosing where the focus goes and bringing it back there when it wanders — which is the part you actually train.
CONFIDENCE	In the doctrine it is not a mood: it is the accumulated product of having delivered on small things. It is built from the bottom up.

THE ONE THAT PAYS OFF MOST IN THE GYM: THE PROCESS GOAL

An outcome goal —lose eight kilos, lift a hundred— depends on things you do not fully control and only answers you at the end. A process goal —three sessions this week, vegetables at the main meal— you control entirely, and it answers you every day.

The practical recommendation is to have both and to score yourself only on the second. The outcome goal sets the direction; the process goal is what produces the behaviour, and punishing yourself over an

outcome goal that moves slowly is the most efficient way to quit while you are doing everything right.



SELF-TALK: HOW IT ACTUALLY CHANGES

The instruction to “think positive” does not work, because you cannot stop thinking something by deciding to. What you can do is have another sentence ready, short and concrete, and use it as a replacement. The doctrine insists on instructional phrases —ones that say what to do — over motivational ones.

REPLACEMENTS

“I CAN'T DO THIS”	“Two more reps, then I reassess”
“I FEEL TERRIBLE TODAY”	“Today is a floor day. Ten minutes”
“I'M GOING TOO SLOWLY”	“I'm going. And this is the part that makes the difference”
“I'VE ALREADY BROKEN IT”	“One data point. Next meal, normal plan”

WHY A MILITARY INSTITUTION WORKS AS A SOURCE HERE

For two specific reasons. The first is that it is not selling anything: there is no product behind its doctrine, which is rare in this sector. The second is that it operates at a scale where things that only work on highly motivated people are useless, because it has to train everyone, including the majority who do not want to be there. That requirement produces a robust method, and it is exactly the requirement of anyone who wants to sustain a habit for ten years.

GOALS THAT ARE ACTUALLY GOOD FOR SOMETHING

Goal setting appears in the public mental-readiness doctrine and in the behaviour-change section of the physical activity guidelines. It is also the thing that gets done worst: almost every goal people set breaks at least two of the conditions that would make it useful.

THE THREE LEVELS

A GOAL HAS THREE HEIGHTS, AND YOU NEED ALL THREE

OUTCOME	Where you want to get to. It depends partly on things you do not control and only answers you at the end. It is there to give direction, not to score yourself by.
PERFORMANCE	A concrete, measurable mark on something that does depend on you: a weight, a time, a number of reps. It is the bridge between the other two.
PROCESS	What you are going to do this week. You control it entirely and it answers you every day. It is the only one to score yourself by.

The universal mistake is having only the first. “I want to lose eight kilos” does not tell you what to do on Tuesday, does not congratulate you for doing it, and on top of that punishes you over a number that

swings for reasons unrelated to your behaviour. It is a goal designed to demoralise someone who is doing it right.



HOW TO WRITE A PROCESS GOAL

- 1 A concrete behaviour, not an intention. “Three strength sessions”, not “train more”.
- 2 Small amounts and short horizons. A week, not a quarter. A three-month goal corrects nothing until it is already too late.
- 3 Ambition calibrated to the worst week you might have, not the best. If it only gets done when everything goes well, it is badly sized.
- 4 With a binary success criterion. At the end of the week the answer has to be yes or no, with no interpretation.
- 5 Written down. A goal that exists only in your head renegotiates itself, and always downwards.

AND ONE MORE THING, WHICH ALMOST NOBODY DOES

Also write down what you will do when it is NOT met. Not as a punishment but as a procedure: if this week comes out two out of three, do I lower the goal, hold it, or change whatever was getting in the way? Deciding in advance avoids the conversation that actually does damage — the one that begins with “so this isn’t for me”.

THE MONTHLY REVIEW, IN FOUR QUESTIONS

What got done? What did not? Which specific situation got in the way most often? What ONE thing do I change next month? Four questions, ten minutes, once a month. That is more than ninety per cent of people who have been training for years ever do.

CHAPTER 9

AROUSAL AND BREATHING

Arousal control is one of the skills the public doctrine describes as trainable, and it is the most immediate of them all: you feel it on the first attempt, unlike the rest of this book.

AROUSAL IS NOT THE SAME THING AS MOTIVATION

Arousal is how switched on the system is: heart rate, muscle tension, speed of thought. There is a level that is too low —flat, slow, no spark— and a level that is too high —racing, scattered, technique falling apart— and between the two there is a band where you perform best. The band is not the same for everything: a maximal strength set calls for a high level; a technical session or a difficult conversation calls for considerably less.

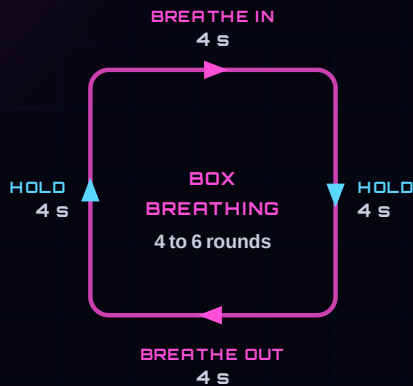
THE TWO DIRECTIONS

TO GO UP

Short, fast breathing, movement, music, an upright posture, a clap, action-words. Useful for the heavy set and for the day you do not feel like it.

TO COME DOWN

A long exhale, slow counted breathing, unclenching jaw and shoulders, focus on one single thing. Useful before sleep, after an argument, and between sets of a session that has got out of hand.



FOUR EQUAL COUNTS · IT LOWERS AROUSAL, IT DOES NOT FILL THE LUNGS

BOX BREATHING Four equal counts: breathe in, hold, breathe out, hold. What lowers arousal is lengthening the exhale and holding without tension, not filling the lungs.

Four equal counts. What brings arousal down is lengthening the exhale and holding without tension, not filling the lungs.

- 1 Breathe in through the nose for a count of 4.
- 2 Hold for 4, without clenching.
- 3 Breathe out for 4, slowly, as if blowing on a candle without putting it out.
- 4 Hold for 4 and start again. 4 to 6 rounds are enough.

If a count of four feels long, start with three. If it makes you dizzy, you are filling up too much: the aim is not to breathe a lot, it is to breathe slowly and on a fixed rhythm.



WHERE TO ACTUALLY USE IT

- In the last few minutes before bed, which is where it pays off most and where you notice it most the next day.
- Between sets, if the session has turned frantic and the technique is falling apart.
- Before a situation you know winds you up: a test, a presentation, a conversation.
- After a lapse in the plan, BEFORE deciding what you do. The chapter on relapse says the decision that matters comes after the lapse; this is the tool for taking it with a cool head.

WHAT IT IS NOT

It is not meditation, it does not cure anxiety and it does not replace treatment. It is a simple physiological lever that lowers arousal for a few minutes. If the anxiety is persistent and interferes with your life, that is grounds for seeing someone, and no breathing technique resolves it.

MEASURING YOURSELF WITHOUT PUNISHING YOURSELF

Self-monitoring is one of the behaviour-change strategies the guidelines mention explicitly, and it is also the place where most people hurt themselves. The difference lies in what gets logged and how it is read.

THE PROBLEM WITH THE SCALE

Body weight swings by several kilos within days for reasons that have nothing to do with fat: water, salt, glycogen, gut contents, hormonal cycle, heat. Someone who weighs themselves daily and takes every figure seriously is reacting emotionally to noise, and over any short window the noise is bigger than the signal.

- If you weigh yourself, always do it under the same conditions and look at the seven-day average against the previous week's average. Never one day against another day.
- If the scale ruins your day, the correct solution is to stop weighing yourself. That is not dodging the problem: the scale is an optional tool and there are others.
- Waist measurements, how your clothes fit and a monthly photograph taken under the same conditions give better information with far less emotional noise.

WHAT IS WORTH LOGGING

THREE RECORDS WORTH MORE THAN YOUR WEIGHT

ADHERENCE	How many sessions and how many meals of the plan, out of those scheduled. It is the variable that rules, so it is the one to look at.
PERFORMANCE	Weight lifted, reps, time over a known route. It goes up before any visible change does, and it is exactly the kind of immediate reward this book asks you to manufacture.
STATE	Sleep, energy, appetite for the next session, pain. Three words a day are enough, and it is what gives you warning before something breaks.

The point of the log is not to judge you: it is to have data you can change the plan with. A notebook that produces guilt rather than decisions is badly designed, and should be cut back until it produces decisions.



THE RIGHT HORIZON

Anything judged over less than a month is being judged on noise. Body composition moves in months; strength, in weeks; mood and sleep, in days. It is worth knowing how fast each thing moves so that you do not check the scale as often as you check your mood.

HOW FAST EACH THING CHANGES

HOURS

Mood and anxiety after a session, the quality of that night's sleep, insulin sensitivity

WEEKS

Strength, perceived endurance, technique, blood pressure

MONTHS

Body composition, muscle size, measured aerobic capacity

YEARS

Bone density, cardiovascular risk, independence in old age

CHAPTER 11

DESIGN THE ENVIRONMENT BEFORE THE WILLPOWER

This chapter comes down to one idea: willpower is an exhaustible resource and the environment is not. Every decision you manage to remove from the day is a decision that cannot be lost.

FRICTION: REMOVE IT WHERE YOU WANT TO GO, ADD IT WHERE YOU DO NOT

THE TWENTY-SECOND RULE

FOR WHAT YOU WANT TO DO

Get the time-to-start under twenty seconds. Clothes ready, bag packed, dumbbells in plain sight, gym on your way and not on a detour.

FOR WHAT YOU DO NOT

Add twenty seconds. Whatever you do not want to eat daily should not be in the house; if it is, it goes in a high cupboard in an opaque container. This is not willpower: it is distance.

This sounds like a minor trick and it is probably the intervention with the best effort-to-result ratio in the whole book, because it acts hundreds of times without consuming anything. The shop is the moment at which almost all of the week's eating is decided, and it is done once, in a reasonable state, with time to spare. That is where the effort belongs, not in the kitchen at ten at night.



PEOPLE ARE ENVIRONMENT TOO

Social support appears among the strategies the guidelines mention, and in practice it works through two distinct routes that are worth not confusing: company —doing it with someone, which makes the session happen— and public commitment —saying it out loud, which makes not going costly. The first works for almost everyone; the second works well for some and produces shame and quitting in others.

- If you are one of the latter, commit to a single person rather than a group, and commit to the process —“I’m going three days”— rather than to the outcome.
- An appointment with someone else is harder to cancel than an appointment with yourself. That asymmetry is a tool, not a flaw.
- And a warning: the environment pushes the other way too. If there is pressure at home or at work to eat or drink a certain way, that is a real obstacle and it deserves a written if-then, not improvised willpower.

THE SHORT VERSION OF THE WHOLE CHAPTER

Do not decide well: decide less. Every thing you settle in advance — the shopping, the clothes, the schedule, the sentence for the bad moment— is a battle you will not have to win at the worst moment of the day.

CHAPTER 12

IDENTITY, COMPARISON AND THE NOISE FROM OUTSIDE

The previous chapters deal with the mechanics. This one deals with two things that surround them and that decide more than they appear to: how you describe yourself, and who you compare yourself with.

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN DOING AND BEING

“I’m trying to train” and “I’m someone who trains” describe the same behaviour and behave differently in the face of a lapse. The first turns every missed session into evidence that the attempt is not going well. The second turns it into an exception by someone who, generally speaking, trains.

And this is not self-deception or positive thinking, because the sentence is earned with data: two months of notebook with most of the boxes ticked is the evidence. The correct sequence runs from behaviour to identity and not the other way round. First small pieces of evidence accumulate, then the description changes by itself, and from there maintenance costs far less.

- Start with behaviours so small that the evidence is immediate. The floor from chapter four is for exactly this.

- State what you do in the present tense and without epic adjectives: “I train three days a week” says more and holds up better than “I’m on a transformation journey”.
- When you slip, describe the fact and not the person. “I didn’t go on Tuesday” is a data point; “I’ve got no staying power” is a prophecy.



COMPARISON, WHICH IS THE TAX OF THIS AGE

Comparing yourself with others is unavoidable and not always bad: someone a little ahead of you is a useful reference. The problem is who you end up comparing yourself with when an algorithm picks the reference, because what you see is not a sample of people: it is a selection of the extreme cases, edited, in flattering light, and without the years that sit behind it.

THREE CORRECTIONS THAT WORK

COMPARE YOURSELF WITH YOUR OWN LOG	Last month's notebook is the only comparison you can actually do something with.
ADJUST WHAT YOU CONSUME	If an account leaves you worse off every time you see it, stop seeing it. That is not weakness: it is modifying the environment, which is the best-documented strategy in this whole book.
BE SUSPICIOUS OF TIMEFRAMES	Any transformation with a date on it hides earlier years, genetics, circumstances, or outright pharmacology. The timeframe is the part that almost always lies.

AND THE NOISE CLOSE TO HOME, WHICH WEIGHS MORE

Family, partner and work influence you a good deal more than any account on the internet does, and not always in your favour. There are households where eating a particular way or heading out to train creates real friction, and pretending that willpower resolves it is a sign of never having lived in one.

What does work is treating it as what it is —a foreseeable situation — and writing its if-then: exactly what you do at the family dinner, at the work lunch, on the weekend at your parents' house. Decided in advance, in the cold, and without turning it into a moral issue with anyone.

AN HONEST LIMIT

If the environment is not merely unhelpful but actively hostile —if there is control, systematic mockery, or pressure about what you eat or about your body— that is no longer a problem of adherence and this book is not the tool. It is a different conversation, and sometimes it is a conversation with a professional.

CHAPTER 13

COMING BACK AFTER MONTHS AWAY

Every previous chapter is about sustaining something. This one is about the other situation, which is more common: you have gone months or years without doing anything and you want to come back. It deserves its own chapter because the rules are different and because almost everybody does it equally badly.

THE THREE MISTAKES OF COMING BACK

STARTING WHERE YOU LEFT OFF

Memory keeps the best moment, not the average. Going back to the weight or the pace of that time is the fast route to the second-week injury, because muscle recovers faster than tendon.

STARTING EVERYTHING AT ONCE

Diet, gym, sleep, supplements and a new app all on the same Monday. Five simultaneous changes is zero sustained changes, and on top of that it makes it impossible to know which one was working.

STARTING AS A PUNISHMENT

Coming back as penance for the months lost guarantees that the activity ends up attached to an emotion nobody repeats voluntarily.

THE FOUR-WEEK PROTOCOL

- 1 Week 1: just turn up. Two very easy sessions, half of what you think you can do. The goal is that they exist, not that they achieve anything.
- 2 Week 2: the same two sessions, one notch harder. Add a single thing on the food side, the easiest one of all.
- 3 Week 3: three sessions if the previous two came off. If they did not, repeat week 2 without drama: the plan was too big and now you know it.
- 4 Week 4: measure something. A weight, a time, one simple test: max push-ups, plank in seconds, or distance covered in twelve minutes. That number is your real starting point, and from here on you are training, not coming back.

Four weeks look like too few for a two-year comeback and they are exactly what is needed: what is being built is not fitness, it is the habit of turning up. The fitness comes afterwards, and it comes by itself if the habit holds.



WHAT IS ON YOUR SIDE, AND ALMOST NOBODY TELLS YOU

Regaining is faster than building for the first time. Someone who once had muscle mass gets it back faster than someone who never had it, and this is observed fairly consistently. The first two months of a

comeback tend to be surprisingly good, and it is worth knowing for two reasons: to start with less reluctance, and so as not to mistake that initial speed for the normal rate and get frustrated when it levels off.

IF THE BREAK WAS DUE TO INJURY OR ILLNESS

Then the step is set by whoever treated you and not by this book. The protocol above is for a break caused by a busy life, not for a return after surgery, a cardiac event, a pregnancy or a prolonged illness. In those cases, the first session is an appointment.

HOW TO CHECK IT YOURSELF



f everything this work deals with, behaviour is what has the least official backing available, and that is why this chapter is indispensable. Here it is set out, line by line, which parts come from a public source and which are a conceptual framework in common use.

THE SOURCES OF THIS BOOK

DIETARY REFERENCE INTAKES	National Academies · distributed by the NIH Office of Dietary Supplements. RDA, AI and UL for vitamins and minerals.
PHYSICAL ACTIVITY GUIDELINES FOR AMERICANS, 2ND ED.	U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, 2018. Activity dose and the response curve.
DIETARY GUIDELINES FOR AMERICANS	USDA and HHS. Dietary patterns and limits for added sugars, saturated fat and sodium.
FOODDATA CENTRAL	USDA Agricultural Research Service. Food composition, searchable online at no cost.
FM 7-22 HOLISTIC HEALTH AND FITNESS	U.S. Army. Doctrine on physical training, nutrition, sleep and mental readiness, published in full.
THE NIOSH LIFTING EQUATION	National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health, CDC. Calculation of the recommended weight limit in manual handling.
RESEARCH ON UNLOADING AND BED REST	NASA Human Research Program. Effects of unloading on muscle, bone and the cardiovascular system.
REGISTER OF HEALTH CLAIMS	European Commission, with the scientific assessments of EFSA. What may be claimed about a nutrient, and what was applied for and refused.



WHAT IN THIS BOOK COMES FROM AN OFFICIAL SOURCE

- The five domains of readiness and the mental performance skills — goals, mental rehearsal, self-talk, arousal control, attention and

confidence— are in FM 7-22, Holistic Health and Fitness, published in full by the U.S. Army and downloadable from its publications library.

- The behaviour-change strategies —goals, self-monitoring, social support, modifying the environment— appear in the Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans, second edition, at health.gov.
- The acute benefits of a single session on mood, anxiety, sleep and insulin sensitivity are in those same guidelines, and they are the basis for the advice about manufacturing an immediate reward.
- The reference dose used as a target —150 to 300 moderate minutes and 2 days of strength work— comes from the verified data module this book runs before it is typeset, not from a figure typed by hand into the text.

WHAT DOES NOT COME FROM AN OFFICIAL SOURCE, SAID PLAINLY

- The cue–routine–reward scheme is classic material from the psychology of learning, not a government recommendation.
- If-then plans come from academic literature in the psychology of motivation that is not in the public domain. What is described here is the mechanism, which is common sense, without reproducing any text.
- The “since I’ve broken it anyway” phenomenon is described in the relapse-prevention literature, which is also not in the public domain. The plate and the protocol in this book are original.

- The practical twenty-second friction rule is a popular formulation in common use: useful, and with no institutional backing.

I make this separation because a book that wraps everything in the words “scientifically proven” is asking you to trust without checking, and this book is built on the opposite. The conceptual part of this book is worth whatever it is worth on its own merits, not because of whose name is on it.

THE NOTEBOOK OF THE WILL

Four weeks. It does not measure the body: it measures behaviour and the situations that break it. It is uncomfortable to keep and it is the one that changes the most decisions.

WEEK 1 · LOGGING WITHOUT JUDGEMENT

- 1** Every day, two lines: what you did of the plan and what you did not.
- 2** Next to each lapse, the situation —not the excuse—: where you were, what time it was, who with, how you had slept.
- 3** No adjectives about yourself in the notebook. “I didn’t go” is a data point; “I’m a disaster” is nothing at all.
- 4** Do not change the plan this week.

WEEK 2 · DEFINING THE FLOOR

- 1** Write your non-negotiable minimum version, for training and for food. Make it so small that it slightly embarrasses you.
- 2** Commit only to the floor for the whole week. Anything you do above it is extra and counts for nothing.
- 3** Mark every day on a calendar you can see. It is a cheap immediate reward and it works better than it looks.

- 4 At the end of the week, count the days. If it was not seven, the floor was too high: lower it. Yes, again.

WEEK 3 · THE IF-THENS

- 1 Go back to week 1 and find the three situations where the lapses repeat.
- 2 Write an if-then for each one. Concrete in both halves and executable without thinking.
- 3 Put them where you will see them: the fridge, your phone wallpaper, the door.
- 4 When one of the three situations comes up, note whether the if-then fired or not. If it did not, it is almost always because it was too abstract.

WEEK 4 · THE LAPSE TEST

- 1 This week the goal is not to comply: it is to practise the return. When you slip—and you will, that is what the week is for— apply the twenty-four-hour protocol.
- 2 Log the lapse, do not compensate, come back at the next meal or the next day.
- 3 Note how long you took to come back. That number, and not the number of lapses, is the real measure of your adherence over a twelve-month horizon.
- 4 Compare week 4 with week 1. What you are looking for is not fewer lapses: it is faster returns.

WHAT TO EXPECT FROM THE NOTEBOOK

It will not make you more disciplined, because discipline is not what is failing. What it will give you is a floor that holds, three written sentences for your three difficult situations, and the habit of coming back in a day rather than in a month. With that, whatever plan you choose —any reasonable one— starts to have an effect, which was the problem from the beginning.

WHAT NO PLAN CAN FIX

The closing chapter, and the most important limit in the whole book. There are things that look like a lack of discipline and are not, and treating them as if they were does harm.

WHEN THIS STOPS BEING A FITNESS MATTER

- If eating has become a constant source of guilt, if there are episodes of bingeing, if there are compensatory behaviours —vomiting, laxatives, exercise as punishment— or if counting food occupies your head for most of the day, that is an eating disorder and not a problem of adherence. This book does not help there and can make it worse. Seek professional help, and the sooner the better: the prognosis depends heavily on that.
- If you cannot stop training even when injured or ill, if missing a session produces intense distress, or if exercise has displaced work and relationships, that is not a virtue either. It is the same mechanism with the sign reversed.
- If the lack of energy and desire lasts for weeks and affects everything, not just the gym, the question is not how to get motivated: it is whether there is a depression or a medical problem behind it. Blood work and an appointment before a plan.
- If sleep is persistently bad despite doing things right, there are common, treatable medical causes: apnoea, chronic insomnia, restless

legs syndrome. None of them is fixed with discipline and all of them have treatment. That is something to see a doctor about.

I say this in the book about mindset and nowhere else on purpose, because this is where the fitness industry says “you just need to want it more” and where that sentence does the most harm. None of the four situations above is resolved with a notebook, and all of them resolve reasonably well with the right help.



GLOSSARY

ADHERENCE	The degree to which the plan is actually followed. The variable that rules the long-term outcome.
SELF-MONITORING	Writing down your own behaviour. One of the change strategies mentioned by the official guidelines.
FRICTION	Everything that sits between the intention and the behaviour. Measured in steps and in seconds.
PROCESS GOAL	A goal about what you do, not about what you achieve. It is the only one you control.
IF-THEN PLAN	A sentence tying a specific situation to a specific behaviour, decided in advance.
CUE	What sets a behaviour off. The cheapest lever in the loop.
FLOOR	The non-negotiable minimum version of the plan. It protects the behaviour, not the result.



And with that the book closes. It does not bring motivation, because motivation cannot be given away in a book. It brings the other thing: a wheel for working out where to start, a floor that holds through the bad days, sentences written in advance for the situations that break your plan, a twenty-four-hour protocol for after a lapse, and the idea —the most useful of them all— that a lapse means nothing until you decide it does.

If a year from now you still have a defined floor and the habit of coming back the next day rather than on Monday, this book will have done its job. Everything else is scaffolding to get to those two things.

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